money to go and have a *vada pav* (a popular Mumbai fast food) or a soft drink as a treat.

Between 5 p.m. and 7 p.m. I'd have five more net sessions, before a final session of fifteen minutes, when Sir would place a one-rupee coin on top of the stumps and if I managed to avoid getting out, the coin was mine. In this session every bowler in the camp would come and have a go at me, with some sixty to seventy boys fielding. Even if the ball was caught 90 yards away, which was a distance bigger than the boundary length at any school ground in India, I was out. It meant I had to hit every ball along the ground to survive those intense fifteen minutes. It was a serious challenge but with time I started enjoying this session the most. Winning the one-rupee coin used to give me immense satisfaction and taught me how to concentrate even when physically drained.

At the end of it all, Sir would tell me to run two full circuits of Shivaji Park with my pads and gloves on. That was the last part of my training and I'd be completely exhausted by the end of it all. It was a routine I would repeat right through during my summer holidays and it helped me to build up physical and mental stamina.

Occasionally my father came to take me home and I would always ask him to treat me to a special fruit cocktail at a juice centre near the club. While this regular demand was a little unreasonable, because at the time I did not realize that my parents also had to take care of the needs of my brothers and sister, my father would invariably end up giving me what I wanted, just to see me happy.

On other days, when I made my way home from Shivaji Park on my own, I'd often fall asleep on the bus – if I managed to sit down, that is. Anyone who has been on a Mumbai bus at peak hours will know just how difficult it is to get a seat. On days when I wasn't so lucky, it was still a challenge just to stand with the kitbag, because the bus conductors would inevitably complain about me taking up the space of another passenger. It could be embarrassing because the conductors were often rude and would sometimes ask me to buy two tickets. I didn't have the money for a second ticket and I had to learn to take these remarks in my stride. Dirty clothes often added to the embarrassment. After I'd played in them all day, the clothes were usually in quite a smelly state and this was the cause of a lot of discomfort and guilt on the way home. With time I evolved a way of wrapping the kitbag around me. Just as the